



Going retro

Publishers can revive old titles by upgrading the graphics themselves. Dark Athena is a recent example



Level editing

Game modification can be as simple as editing levels of your favorite games. Try creating levels for Pingus or Moto X.

maps, better spawn locations and better weapons balance. Due to this, players that knew the maps, knew the spawn points, and the timings at which any item spawned, could navigate to these items better than those that were new to the map. This practice is known as 'resource hoarding', where getting an item gives the particular person an advantage. *Rocket Arena* was one modification that threw all these design considerations in the bin. Players started with a lot of ammo, all the weapons, the armour and health maxed out. There were no items in the maps at all, and the players just had to battle it out with what they had. The modifications could be so versatile, that there were a few racing games made using the *Quake 3* engine. Since the source code of the engine was released, there have been many successful total conversions of the game. These are not just mods that can be played by loading the mod using the original game, but stand-alone, re-distributable games that are totally independent of *Quake 3*. *Urban Terror*, *Alien Arena*, *Open Arena*, *Warsow* and *Tremulous* are just some



Warsow, an artistic modification of *Quake 3 Arena*

of the free, stand-alone multiplayer games based on the *Quake 3* engine. You could play Pro Mode on a third party map using custom avatars. The versatility of the *Quake 3* engine also allowed modders to create maps specifically for the skill of the users in using weapons for movement, called 'trickjumping'. *DeFrag* was one of these mods, where the aim of the game was creating speedruns on *DeFrag* maps, and showing off trick jumping techniques. The *Quake* engine has also been heavily used by the Machinima community, and in fact, gave birth to that technique of animation.

Boom! headshot

Another game that was heavily modded was Valve's *Half Life*. A number of modders who had worked on .WAD files in the *Doom* days were part of the development team of *Half Life*, so the game was purposely made to be modder-friendly. The game itself came with a bunch of toolkits to help modders, including the *Hammer Toolkit* which was meant for editing maps. There were two kinds of mods that originated from *Half Life*. Single

player mods had a storyline or scenarios for a player to cross. *Wanted!* is one of the most famous of these, which had a wild west themed storyline. The game was later on bundled with a commercial release of *Counter Strike*, a multi-player *Half Life* mod, based on *Half Life*'s 'Goldsrc' engine.

Counter Strike started as a mod of *Half Life*, but grew on to become a stand alone game. *Counter Strike* is one of the biggest success stories of the modscene. *Counter Strike* remains till date the most played game online, in LAN parties, and at gaming tournaments. There were other *Half Life* multi-player mods too, like *Day of Defeat* and *Firearms*, but these were not embraced as wholeheartedly by gamers. *Counter Strike* had many iterations, including *Counter Strike: Condition Zero*, and *Counter Strike: Source*, the latter was based on the Source engine used in *Half Life 2*. *Counter Strike* has also been ported to the Xbox console.

The easy access to the code of the game allowed *Quake 3* and *Counter Strike* modders to create scripts and aimbots that put other players in a gameplay environment at a



A *Counter Strike H4X* that let's players see through walls

heavy disadvantage. These ranged from guns that automatically targetted players, allowing users to see through walls, or cones in front of other players that showed where they were looking.

This heavily changed the kill to death ratio of the gamers using these fixes, called H4X. Servers would use cheat detection scripts to deter these, Punkbuster in *Quake* and the VAC for the official *Counter Strike* Servers. Although these were very effective, really crafty users could and can still get around these prevention mechanisms. The server operators usually ban players with disproportionate kill ratios.

Modding today

Neverwinter Nights was one of the first MMORPGs that allowed for the creation and sharing of a lot of user made content. The game shipped with the *Aurora toolset* that allowed users to edit the different aspects of the game in a stand-alone editor, save their creations as 'modules' and then play them or distribute them. The tool set could change or resize objects, add textures

to them, change the locations of in-game cameras, change the behaviour of units, and skin the GUI of the game. *Neverwinter Nights* is remembered as one of the few MMORPG games that encouraged user-made content. The changes were largely superficial, with a few power tools for modifying beneath the surface. However, the source code was not released with any license that allowed the users to create stand-alone games.

RTS games such as *Battlefield 1942*, *Age of Empires*, *Command and Conquer*, *Rise of Nations* and the *Warcraft* series have all been modded to various degrees. The approach is to create an RTS games for a particular universe, such as the *Lord Of The Rings* legendarium or the *Star Wars* continuum. Units, scenarios, maps and campaigns are made for these universes and distributed over the internet. *Civilisation IV* is a very modder-friendly RTS games, which allows users to change any aspect of the game using python scripts. *GTA Vice City* is another popular game for modding. Modders for these games focus on realism, adding objects, or adding storylines to the



Crysis Sandbox, a level editor for *Crysis*

game, instead of total conversions. Total conversions have been made, but many of these require a licenced version of the original game, so have not spread as much as *Quake* or *Half Life* based stand alone total conversions.

Crysis is one of the most technologically advanced games to be released in recent times. Its engine, *CryEngine2*, is cutting edge. Despite this, even before the game itself was released, the engine and toolsets to create mods were released to select modding clans for the creation of mods based on the engine. The web site www.crymod.com is an official portal for *Crysis* based mods. The sandbox toolkit that ships with the game can be used to create, edit and share maps with other players. This is another example of publishers supporting the development community.

How friendly a new game is to modding has now become an important consideration for video game publishers. The ability to allow users to easily create and share user made content has become an important factor in the gameplay experience. **d**